HEURISTIC EVALUATION · NIELSEN'S 10

Rabbit Hole — usability findings

Build **6eaafe1** (main) · Chrome extension popup, Settings & dashboard · 9 October 2026 · single evaluator (AI-assisted expert review)

Verdict: ready for user testing — fix one thing before a wider release.

The core loop works and is **unusually honest**: it shows what it searched, explains every recommendation, and never pads results. The one major problem is recovery when Reddit blocks the extension — the message sends people to Settings with no way to get there, and retrying keeps failing for up to 15 minutes. The rest is polish: results start too far down, and some wording assumes technical knowledge.

0	1	3	3
catastrophic (4)	major (3)	minor (2)	cosmetic (1)

Severity 0–4 (Nielsen): 4 must fix before release · 3 high priority · 2 low priority · 1 fix if time allows

Scorecard — the 10 heuristics

#	HEURISTIC	STATUS	WORST	WHAT WE SAW
H1	Visibility of system status	Good	3	Skeletons, "Finding…", "Found 5 related articles on Substack and Medium", query chips. But the Reddit **cool-down after a block is invisible** (#1).
H2	Match with the real world	Good	2	"Highly / Very relevant / Related", "About this episode" read naturally. **Jargon**: "curated publication list", "search provider", "browser session" (#4).
H3	User control & freedom	Strong	1	Esc clears, "Clear / Back to this video", per-platform detection switches, Medium on/off. No way to dismiss a bad result (#7).
H4	Consistency & standards	Good	1	Card actions consistent (Read on Medium / Substack, Open Reddit, bridges). Orange **dot on both tabs** means nothing; static query chips look clickable (#5).
H5	Error prevention	Strong	0	Nothing is read without consent ("Use this page"), keys are write-only, "Delete everything" asks first, strict matching prevents misleading results.
H6	Recognition rather than recall	Strong	0	"Watching · Black Mirror · S7 E2" context bar, searched-for chips and "Why this is relevant" keep everything on screen.
H7	Flexibility & efficiency	Good	1	"/", ← →, Enter/Esc, one-click Reddit ⇄ reading bridges, full dashboard. "Search Reddit" on an empty result doesn't pre-fill the show (#6).
H8	Aesthetic & minimalist design	Needs work	2	Calm, consistent dark UI. But on Related Reading the **first result starts ~78% down** the popup (#2).
H9	Recognise & recover from errors	Fix first	3	Netflix fallback and empty states are exemplary. **Reddit-blocked recovery is broken in practice** (#1).
H10	Help & documentation	Good	2	"What Rabbit Hole used" and the Privacy page are clear — once found. **No first-run explanation** of what it reads and sends (#3).

Fix these first

1

Make "Reddit blocked" recoverable in one click

Add **Open Settings** and an inline **"Use my Reddit login"** switch to the error, and **reset the cool-down** when that setting or a client ID changes — so "Try again" works right away.

3 H9 · H1

2

Put the first result above the fold

Collapse the context bar, topic chips and coverage banner into one compact line (expand on tap). Show the coverage banner once, not every time.

2 H8

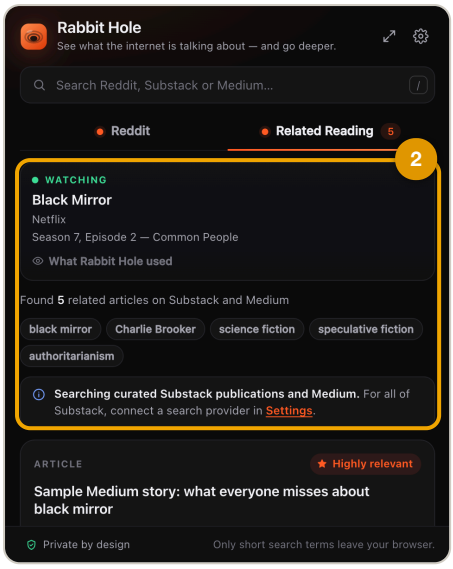
3

Explain the tool on first open — in plain words

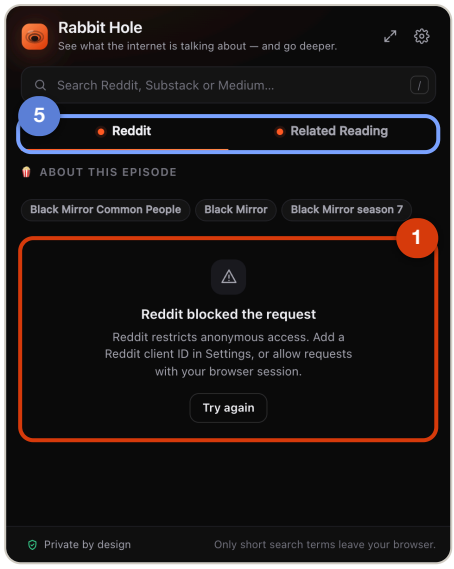
A one-time note: "Reads only the page you have open, when you open it. Sends only topic words." Replace jargon with "we check 60+ hand-picked newsletters".

2 H10 · H2

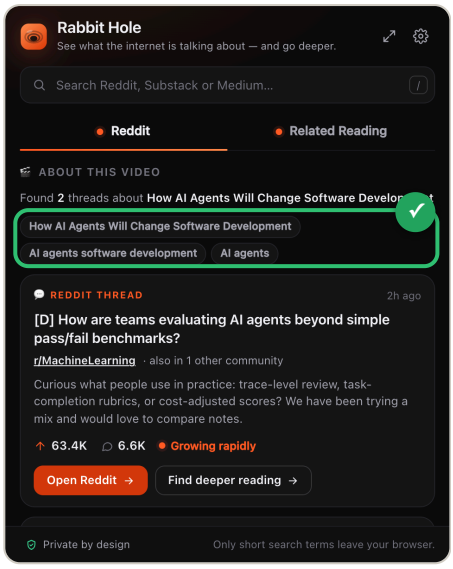
Evidence from the current build



#2 Results start low. Context, 5 topic chips and the coverage banner fill ~78% of the popup before the first article.



#1 Dead end. The fix lives in Settings but the only action is “Try again”, which keeps failing during the cool-down. **#5** Both tabs carry the same dot.



Strength. “Found 2 threads about …” plus the exact searches as chips: users can see — and trust — why these threads appear.

All findings

#	SEV.	HEUR.	PROBLEM (WHERE)	RECOMMENDED FIX
1	3	H9 · H1	**Reddit-blocked recovery** (Reddit tab). Message says “add a client ID in Settings, or allow your browser session” — no link; after changing it, retries still fail for up to 15 min unless the user finds *Clear cache*.	Buttons: *Open Settings* + inline session toggle; reset the provider cool-down on that change; say when it will retry.
2	2	H8	**Results below the fold** (Related Reading, 480×600). The first article title appears at ~78% of the height.	One-line context summary; chips + banner collapsible; banner shown once.
3	2	H10	**No first-run explanation**. Privacy is excellent but only discoverable via the footer or Settings.	Dismissible first-open note: reads / stores / sends, in three short lines.
4	2	H2	**Technical wording**: “curated publication list”, “search provider”, “browser session”, “client ID”.	Plain words + a short “why” link; keep the technical terms in Settings only.
5	1	H4	**Ambiguous signals**: the orange dot shows on both tabs; static query chips look like buttons.	Use the dot for “new results” only; style query chips as plain text or make them searchable.
6	1	H7	**Empty Reddit result** offers “Search Reddit” but only focuses an empty box.	Pre-fill the show / video name so one Enter broadens the search.
7	1	H3	**No “not relevant” control** on cards; one weak match can undermine trust in the list.	A small “Hide” / “Not relevant” action, remembered locally.

Strengths to keep

- **Honesty by design** — strict matching and an honest “No Reddit threads about this yet” instead of filler.
- **“Why this is relevant”** on every article; relevance labels are earned, not decorative.
- **Privacy that users can verify** — “What Rabbit Hole used”, footer promise, nothing read without consent.
- **Graceful fallbacks** — Netflix “couldn’t identify” + manual search; skeletons, never blank screens.
- **Context awareness** — “The Office” + “Basketball” episode search, Substack + Medium in one ranked list.

Method & limits

One evaluator inspected the current build (`6eaafe1`) against Nielsen’s 10 heuristics, rating each problem 0–4 by frequency, impact and persistence. States reviewed: YouTube video, Netflix episode, ordinary site, Reddit blocked, empty results, Settings. Screens use the preview’s sample data; live Reddit results could not be checked from the review machine (Reddit blocked it), while live Medium + Substack results were confirmed in a real-Chrome test.

This is an expert inspection, not user testing. Next step: 3–5 independent evaluators and a 5-person think-aloud test using `docs/Rabbit-Hole-Heuristic-Evaluation-Form.pdf` .